

The War at Home

As American involvement in South Vietnam grew, so too did the size and intensity of the antiwar movement. Although white, middle-class college students became the face of the movement, Americans from all walks of life opposed the war in Vietnam.

◀ BEFORE

The growing Vietnam antiwar movement in the United States had deep roots and broad appeal.

WINDS OF CHANGE

The antiwar protesters had links to supporters among other mass social justice movements of the time, such as the antinuclear movement, the Black American **Civil Rights Movement**, and the Berkeley Free Speech Movement, which advocated for campus reform.

OPPOSING DIEM

Early antiwar demonstrations in the United States opposed US support for the **Diem regime** in South Vietnam, and coincided with commemorations for the victims of **atomic bombs** dropped on Japan.



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Millions of Americans objected to the war in Vietnam, but only a small percentage of them participated in protests against it. Reasons for opposition to US involvement in the war varied dramatically, undermining the strength and solidarity of the antiwar movement as a whole. Pacifists opposed the war on principle, but many more Americans specifically opposed the war in Vietnam out of concern for civilian casualties and doubts about whether the cost—in dollars and American lives—was justified.

Many young men opposed the war out of self-interest; they did not want to fight. Others supported the aim of halting the spread of communism in South Vietnam, but disagreed on how to do so. Some in this group, while supporting the escalation of America's role in the war, advocated withdrawal if the US was not prepared to fight to win.